

Top skills and courses

Going Green: Why Building Sustainability Skills Can Help Advance Your Career



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With the shifting of sustainability practices to the **mainstream**, professionals with green skills are in demand.

According to the **LinkedIn Global Green Skills Report** for 2023, “the increase in demand for green skills is outpacing the increase in supply, raising the prospect of an imminent green skills shortage.” Across the 48 countries

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Building your sustainability skills can help you advance your career in several ways.

- **New Opportunities:** Adding sustainability skills can open doors to new job roles, leadership positions, and sectors focused on green initiatives.
- **Market Relevance:** As industries increasingly prioritize sustainability, equipping yourself with the knowledge and skills in this area makes you even more attractive to potential employers.
- **Innovation Leadership:** Learning sustainability can position you as a change agent within your organization or industry, driving innovative practices — such as resource conservation — that not only benefit the environment but also improve operational efficiency and cost-effectiveness.

To help you upskill during Earth Month, we've unlocked four [LinkedIn Learning](#) courses in our [Sustainability Skills Earth Month 2024](#) collection (free until May 15, 2024) to teach you the foundational concepts of sustainability science and how to implement sustainability strategy into your business.

Start with the basics of sustainability and climate change science

In her LinkedIn Learning course, [Sustainability Foundations: Core Concepts](#), [Amy Luers](#), global director of sustainability science at [Microsoft](#), explains that sustainability has become such a buzzword, it's lost some of its meaning. To help ground us in what the term really means, Luers lays out sustainability's textbook definition: "Economic development that meets the needs of the present without compromising the ability of future generations to meet their own needs." At its heart, sustainability asks us to

While the jargon of sustainability can be overwhelming, Luers says that understanding the three interdependent dimensions of sustainability is the best place to start — environment, economy, and society.

The **environmental dimension** is the foundation of sustainability and includes ecosystems like forests and oceans. These provide critical goods and services like pollination, medicine, and climate regulation. “Maintaining healthy ecosystems is essential to both sustaining economic prosperity and societal wellbeing,” Luers says.

The **economic dimension** helps remind us that markets and industries — and essentially our livelihoods — all depend on the environment. “A sustainable economy,” Luers says, “is one that can utilize the goods and services that nature provides without depleting resources.” For instance, overfishing can seem profitable at first, but ultimately can lead to a collapse of the fish population — which then causes fisheries to close, people to lose jobs, and the marine ecosystem to be jeopardized.

The **societal dimension** of sustainability goes beyond ensuring everybody’s basic needs are met and expands to ensuring that there is equality and equity across generations. “Societies full of disparities, inequalities, or injustices,” Luers says, “are inherently unstable, and more prone to conflicts and crises.”

Luers stresses that each dimension depends on and affects the others. “When one [dimension] suffers, it can strain the entire system,” she says.

To build your sustainability foundational skills, check out these two courses:

1. [Sustainability Foundations: Core Concepts](#) with [Amy Luers](#) | Skills Covered: Environmental Sustainability

Governance (ESG)

Once you've learned the basics of sustainability, you can learn how to implement sustainable practices into your business to reduce strain on the environment and boost operational efficiency.

Address climate change with sustainable business practices

With the changing climate and environment, it's clear we need to adapt how we do business.

According to a report recently released by the **United Nation's Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change (IPCC)**, "Climate change is a threat to human well-being and planetary health. . . . There is a rapidly closing window of opportunity to secure a liveable and sustainable future for all." The report outlines how the actions we take over the next decade will have an impact on how livable our planet is for centuries to come.

The LinkedIn Green Skills Report highlights that to address this enormous task of reducing greenhouse gas emissions, we need "a whole-of economy shift — across industries, roles, and geographical regions. With every challenge comes opportunity: If we take the right approach, we can leverage our efforts on behalf of the environment to catalyze growth throughout the global economy."

In the course **Sustainability Strategies**, **David Bennell**, a global sustainability strategies and ESG consultant, packs his course with strategies to bring sustainable practices to your business, from considering your supply chain to moving towards zero waste. This can enhance brand reputation, improve efficiencies, and ensure the business maintains its social license to operate — as in, the general public's acceptance that the business is being run in a responsible and beneficial-to-society way.

indicators, but also by considering social and environmental factors that are material to the business. That means anything that can influence the value of a company and its individual share price.”

When companies embrace The Triple Bottom Line, they consider not just profit, but people and the planet to aim for a more sustainable and ethical operation. This broader perspective ensures that business growth is balanced with societal well-being and environmental stewardship, promoting long-term sustainability and social equity.

“Financial research tends to show,” Bennell says, “that companies that actively pursue improvements in environmental and social metrics can have lower cost of capital and higher operational stock price performance.”

Leverage AI to drive sustainability strategy

While implementing sustainable practices can be good for business as well as the environment, there can be roadblocks along the way. In her course, [An Introduction to AI and Sustainability](#), Amy Luers explains the three main roadblocks to developing sustainable solutions and how AI can help us overcome them.

1. **Traditional methods of developing sustainable solutions can be slow and expensive.** For instance, standard research methods to find materials or products that are less carbon-intensive can take years of laboratory time and resources. In contrast to traditional methods, Luers says, “AI can rapidly identify and predict the performance of millions of different chemical compounds and identify the most promising candidates for further testing in weeks rather than years.”
2. **Sustainable solutions require understanding increasingly complex and interconnected social, technical, and biological systems.** As an example, supply chains are very difficult to manage



that supply chains are resilient to climate hazards while optimizing logistics and reducing emissions.”

3. **Demand for sustainable skills is outpacing supply.** Research is showing that a green skills gap is growing. AI can help accelerate learning through individualized training plans, which can help upskill more people to contribute to sustainability efforts. AI can also help people with green skills be more efficient with their time. “AI can help to automate many tasks,” Luers says. “This will allow the world's sustainability workforce to focus on higher-level tasks, such as strategy development and decision making.”

To learn more about implementing sustainable business practices and leveraging AI to drive your sustainability efforts, check out our collection, [Sustainability Skills Earth Month 2024](#), with four courses unlocked through May 15, 2024.

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